

The background is a warm, golden-brown color with a pattern of faint, stylized line drawings of books in various orientations. Scattered throughout are small, out-of-focus white and yellow light spots, creating a bokeh effect.

KR1 PUBLISHING PRESENTS

I JUST SOLD
10K BOOKS
(and you can too)

Karl Otto Kristoffersen

I Just Sold 10,000 Books

(and you can too)

A beginner's guide to selling on DriveThruRPG

Written by Karl Otto Kristoffersen

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kr1publishing.com

Every sales figure in this book comes from the author's own
DriveThruRPG account, exported July 2026.

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Contents

Let me guess	3
How it actually happened	6
The Roadmap.....	10
1. Make.....	11
2. Give	13
3. Grow.....	16
4. Sell	19
The honest timeline	23
Your first step this week	26
What comes next	27
The Checklist	28

Let me guess

You make things, but don't know the next step.

I am going to guess that you make things. Maybe an adventure, perhaps tables and tools, or a whole system that has lived in your scattered notes for years. Your friends have played it and seriously loved it, and your drawer (or hard drive) is slowly filling up with worlds.

And somewhere in the back of your mind, you keep asking the same question. Would anyone out there actually pay for this?

But there is a problem. You have no audience yet. You're not a DungeonTuber with thousands of followers, and you don't know where to begin.

The fear of creative exposure is real. I know all about it. What happens if you announce your thing to the world, put a price on it, and the answer is deafening silence? What if nobody cares?

This little book exists to help you past that wall. It hands you the roadmap that I discovered along the way. It consists of four phases.

- **Make** one small, finished thing.
- **Give** it away, and let it gather names for you.
- **Grow** that list by running the loop again.
- **Sell** only once people are waiting for you.

And I can tell you that this works, because I have walked the walk myself.

In 2025, to my surprise, I was ranked one of the best-selling publishers on DriveThruRPG, ahead of studios with real offices and payrolls. And in June 2026, I passed ten thousand books sold. Ten. Thousand. Books. Sold. Surreal.

"Seeing Karl Otto Kristoffersen (#8) and Oddity Press (#9) rubbing shoulders with industry giants such as Cubicle 7 and Onyx Path is notable. It demonstrates that in the digital age, a single creator with a strong idea (such as the West Marches Guidebook) can commercially outperform entire editorial teams."
- GeekNative.com¹

This book started as a talk. I gave it three times at game conventions in Norway, through 2025 and 2026, telling people how those numbers came to be. Back then, they were not yet ten thousand, but they were well into the thousands.



¹ <https://www.geeknative.com/219694/the-unofficial-best-selling-2025-drivethrurpg-publisher-league-table/>

And every time, someone found me afterward with the same look, kind of in half hope and half disbelief, appreciating the insights and at the same time asking how it was really done.

Based on the response, I figured this was worth writing down properly. I gathered the speaker notes and data points, and started writing.

Here is the thing. I did not know any of this was a method while I was living it. I found it after the fact, by sitting down with my own numbers to see what had really moved them.

Everything it took me twenty years to work out, you can have in an evening.

Let me also be clear about what this is. It is the short version, and I'm still writing the full one. But I really needed to get this out. To tell the story, and to give someone in that confusing and frustrating spot a reason to keep going.

The mission of this book is to help more independent (indie) publishers sell their first book. Starting with you.

And I know you will.

Let's go.

How it actually happened

How a nobody hit a bestseller list.

There's no big company behind the numbers. Just a guy with a day job, stolen hours in a busy schedule, and a handful of good people who've helped along the way.

And the road started more than twenty years ago.

I found live roleplaying (LARP) in the early 2000s, and eventually tabletop games around 2005. I fell in love. For the next decade I played, ran games, and built worlds like a possessed maniac. Mostly with my friends and various home groups.

And then, one day, I realized that I was the guy with a full drawer and decided it was time to try publish something. I joined the Norwegian roleplaying community online, started showing my ideas around, threw myself at conversations and creative contests.



The first thing with my name on it came out of one of those contests. Egil², a strange little four-page solo game about brutal viking poetry. It won three prizes, the people's choice among them, and that was of course incredibly encouraging.

Then I worked up the nerve to put it on DriveThruRPG in 2019, for free, out there for the world to judge. I half expected silence.

² <https://www.drivethrurpg.com/en/product/285534/egil-a-solo-rpg-of-brutal-viking-poetry>

But to my surprise, over the next year, five hundred strangers downloaded it. So I pushed my luck even further and put a one-dollar price tag on it. Then, one November day in 2020, a stranger on the other side of the planet actually paid me.

One dollar. For my strange little game. I spent the rest of that night grinning like an idiot. Someone I'd never met had handed over real money for a thing I made in my spare time. So cool!

Being visible in the RPG scene opened another door. That same year a Norwegian publisher, Game Forlag, picked up my game Kvad (another Viking game, yes). It funded on Kickstarter the year after³. Writing to someone else's deadline gave me great insights on working with iterative design, milestones and how to finish.



Meanwhile I kept making small things on the side just for the fun of it, uploading them to DriveThruRPG and experimenting with charging for them. But every time, the price tag cut downloads drastically.

³ Kvad also hit the English market in 2025:
<https://www.backerkit.com/c/projects/game-forlag/kvad-english>

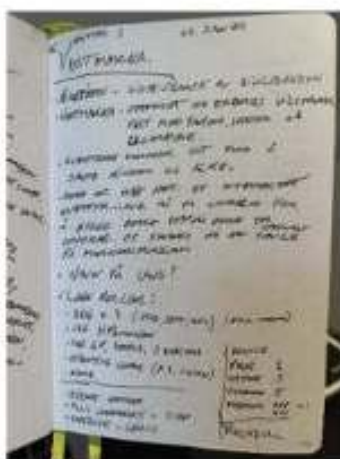
So in the end I gave the small stuff away, figuring it was better that people tried my things than that nobody took them at all.

What I did not understand yet was that they were paying me all along, with their contact information.

With the lessons from Kvad and my own experiments I made a game called Sølvhjerte (Silverheart), self-published in Norwegian in February 2024. It is also a tool for teaching teenagers history in an interactive way at school, which I am really proud of.⁴

It was the biggest thing I had ever charged for, but apart from the school orders it sold slowly. My free stuff, on the other hand, kept flying off the digital shelf.

After Silverheart I decided to spend my creative energy running a small West Marches campaign at my friendly local game store. But the playstyle took some serious research to understand. I read the blogs, watched the videos, and took notes at the table.



⁴ <https://www.karlottokristoffersen.com/post/vellykket-arbeidsseminar>

All of it went into my first West Marches book⁵. When I published it on DriveThruRPG in May 2025, it started selling and did not stop.

I remember refreshing the sales page that first week, thinking it had to be a glitch. It wasn't.

First and foremost, I believe the book solved a problem I'd had myself, deciphering the West Marches playstyle in plain language.

In addition, it had landed in front of thousands of people who had already downloaded my free stuff. Those years of giving things away had been building an audience the whole time.

Lately I've taken the next step and begun publishing other people's games too, not just my own. And somewhere along the way, all those small steps added up to the ten thousand milestone you just read about. There are print editions and shop sales beyond it as well, but every number in this guide comes from DriveThruRPG, because that is where this method lives.

Looking back, I had no head start. I just kept making small things, year after year, and I didn't stop.

That's the whole secret, and it means you can do this too.

Let me show you how it actually works.

⁵ <https://www.drivethrurpg.com/en/product/522853/west-marches-campaign-playstyle-guidebook>

The Roadmap

Four phases, and the order is not optional.

Here's the whole journey up front, so you always know where you are.

1. **Make.** One small, finished thing, solving a specific problem. Not for everyone. For someone.
2. **Give.** Free is how strangers find you. Trade it for the three currencies that matter when nobody knows you: attention, emails, and feedback you can use.
3. **Grow.** Run the loop. Make, give, listen, repeat, until strangers start waiting for your next release.
4. **Sell.** Charge fairly for your best work, and make sure the value beats what you ask.



Notice the order. There is a sequence here, and selling comes last. Each phase makes the next one possible, and I think a lot of people who get stuck are trying to sell before they have anyone to sell to.

After the four phases, we need to talk about how long this really takes. There is also a checklist at the back, with the whole path on one page.

1. Make

One small, finished thing, solving one problem.

It seems like a lot of people fumble this phase, and they fumble it in one or two ways. Making something too big, or too generic (exactly what I did myself in the process of creating Kvad).

This phase is about small steps and quick wins, just enough to get you moving. So at this stage, I'm sorry, your sprawling campaign world must stay in the drawer for a little bit longer. At least for now. This is about making something tiny enough that you could genuinely have it done a week from now, and hand it to a stranger without a string of apologies attached.



My own early stuff was tiny. A four-page solo game about viking poetry. A list of three hundred Viking names, because I needed them at my own table and figured a few other people might too. A one-page OSR adventure about the castle of a red magus. Even a few free 5E logos for other people's crowdfunding projects. None of it was clever, but all of it taught me so much more than the grand projects rotting in my drafts folder.

A finished one-page thing teaches you the whole loop. An unfinished masterpiece teaches you new ways to stall.

To be honest, I still have a folder stuffed with grand unfinished projects. I assume every creator does? Building them is part of the fun. This phase, however, is about a different kind of fun, the kind that ends with something done.

Then decide who it is for. For me that was a tired Game Master (GM) who wanted to run a big, open sandbox campaign and did not have three free weekends to prep it. That person was me, in other words.

The book I wrote for that one tired GM outsold all of them put together, many times over. Some of that was timing, and some of it was the audience those free things had built, which is what the next two chapters are about. But of everyone who came across it, far more of them wanted this one, because it was aimed at a problem they actually had.

So find that problem before you find your idea. What do people actually ask at the table, or type into a forum at midnight? Those questions are worth more than any idea you will come up with on your own, because someone already told you they would like an answer.

Pick the smallest real thing you could finish that answers one of those questions. Finish it, and something shifts. You stop being a person who wants to make things, and become a person who makes them.

That mindset shift is the whole phase.

The Checklist on how to start is available as a printable one-page PDF, free at kripublishing.com

2. Give

Free buys reach, contacts, and usable feedback.

Now you have a small thing, aimed at a real person. Here comes the move that feels completely backwards, and it's the most important one in this guide. Don't sell it. Give it away.

You can't sell to people who don't know you exist. And right now, nobody knows you exist. That little viking game taught me the math. In all the years it has been up, thirty-one people have paid the symbolic dollar. Almost two thousand took it for free, from the very same page.

Thirty-one against two thousand. The zero did all the work.

Why? Not because free is magic. Because nobody knows you yet. A stranger scrolling past your product page has no reason to risk five dollars on a name they have never seen, and no reason not to click something that costs them nothing. Free is the only price that doesn't ask them to trust you first.

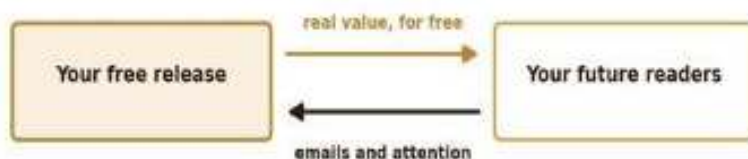
One caveat, though. A free download is a colder lead (potential buyer) than a paid one. People who pay have more skin in the game. They are far more likely to consume the thing, and far more likely to buy again. Free doesn't give you better leads. It gives you more of them, at a stage when you have none.

The first prize is a way to reach them again. On storefronts like DriveThruRPG, some of the people who download your free thing end up following you, and you can mail them through the shop. Mine now have more than three thousand, roughly one in three of everyone who ever grabbed something from my shelf.

One number to keep you sober though. Of those followers, only about one in ten ever bought anything, and that is fine. Free is not where the money comes in. It is where the people come in, and the money follows them later.

But be clear about who those three thousand belong to. They are the platform's customers. I can message them, but I never see who they are, and I cannot take them with me. If DriveThruRPG closed tomorrow, all three thousand would be gone with it.

That is the bargain, and it is worth making. The storefront brings you people you could never have found alone. Just do not mistake reach for ownership. Consider building your own list alongside it, as well. I did not, and it is the one thing on this whole road I probably would go back and change.



The second prize is feedback, and in the beginning it is worth more than money. Every round of making something and giving it away taught me something no theorizing could. Like what people actually used at the table, whether the rules read the way I meant them, if the layout helped or got in the way, and what I was proud of that nobody mentioned at all.

Feedback arrives in two forms, and they answer different questions. Downloads, and feedback.

The download numbers tell you whether your thing found people at all, and if one release pulls three times what the others did, you have probably landed on a problem people actually want solved.

The words, such as comments, reviews and emails, tell you what those people made of it. They are specific and completely opinionated, covering everything from a rule you got wrong, to the font you picked, to whether the whole thing felt worth the download.

The words will swing you from on top of the world to wanting to delete the whole thing. But do not let either make a decision for you. A single review is one person, at one table, on one evening.

One more thing about those early comments. Save the good ones. Screenshot them, keep a folder. A line from a happy reader is the most convincing thing you can put on a product page, and you will never remember where you saw it when you need it.

That's the trade. Value goes out, and attention, emails, and lessons come back. I have given away over eleven thousand books against ten thousand sold, and the free half built the paid half.

Not sure how to set any of this up? Write to me at contact@kr1publishing.com and I'll be happy to help.

3. Grow

Repeat until strangers wait for your next release.

Make a small thing, aim it well, give it away, and listen to what comes back. Growth is what happens when you run that loop repeatedly.

Listening is the part that does the real work, and it's the part a lot of people skip. Putting your work in front of strangers makes you vulnerable, and reading what they say about it makes you more so. The fear does not disappear once you publish, I can assure you. It just changes shape. First, you are afraid nobody will care. Then you are scared of what they will say.

Listen anyway, though you do not have to act on all of it, and certainly not on the loudest voices. But when three different strangers ask for the same thing your book does not have, you have a choice. Fix it in this release, or make it the next one. Either way, you didn't have to guess.

Each pass around the loop of publishing and listening sharpens your craft, lengthens your list, and fills your shelf.

But there is a second reason to keep going, and I only saw it years later, when I finally had enough sales data to look at properly. Buying does not trickle in evenly. It arrives in bursts. Most of it lands right away, when someone first finds you. Then the line goes flat for a long stretch, and much later a second burst arrives, fired every time a new release lands in an inbox or on the storefront front page.

In other words, the people you gathered in the last chapter do not convert on their own. They convert when you show up again. Stop releasing, and that second burst never comes.



That shape has a practical lesson buried in it. A launch that looks flat is not always a failed launch. Knowing how long to wait before you judge a release is worth more than most marketing advice, and it took me years of sales reports to work out. Your list, wherever it lives, is a re-activation engine.

Somewhere along the way, something shifts, and you can feel it when it happens. Your releases stop landing in silence. A new thing goes up and downloads arrive in hours instead of weeks, because there are people out there actually waiting. Names you recognize start reviewing your games. The audience has stopped being an idea and started being a crowd, small, but real, and warm.

Mine has grown to more than eight thousand people who have taken something from my shelf, and among those who paid for something, one in five came back and bought again.

Don't rush this phase, and don't skip it. The size of the crowd matters less than the temperature. A thousand people who actually open what you send will out-earn ten thousand who forgot they signed up. You're not collecting people. You're earning them, one useful free thing at a time.

How did my cadence look like? Slower than you would think. For years it was two or three small things annually, whenever the evenings allowed. Slow enough to keep the day job and the family, steady enough that the shelf kept growing anyway.

And a shelf behaves differently from a single book. One title has to find its own readers every time. Six titles find each other's, so the newest release lifts the oldest one, and the oldest one keeps introducing you to strangers even when you are not looking. That's the compounding nobody sees until it's already working for them.

When a waiting crowd is a real thing, you're standing on solid ground. Which means it is finally time for the phase everyone wants to start with.

4. Sell

Make the value beat the price, and it sells.

By now you have products out in the world, a list of people who chose to hear from you, and a real sense of what they want. That is what earns you the right to charge, and the whole art of it comes down to one line.

$$\text{Value} = (\text{Plus} - \text{Minus}) \times \text{Price}$$

PLUS

everything that helps

↑ raise it

MINUS

friction and drag

↓ cut it

PRICE

money + time + effort

keep it fair

Plus is everything that helps the reader. A clear purpose, plain language, a short smooth path from opening your thing to using it. Every one of these is something you can add deliberately.

Minus is friction inside the thing itself. Too many pages, writing that shows off instead of helping, a structure nobody can navigate, art that fights the text. Every one of these is something you can remove before you publish.

Price is never only money. It's money plus the time and effort before any of it pays off, and it multiplies everything else. Charge too much, demand too many hours, or ask them to learn too much before it works, and the total drops no matter how good the rest of it is.

Of those three, money is usually the smallest cost. A five dollar book they finish is a bargain. A thirty dollar book they never open gave them nothing, and the reason it stayed shut was rarely the price. It was the hours it asked for.

Which gives you the whole job in one sentence. Make the reader feel they got far more than they paid for, and the selling takes care of itself.

That rule has shaped everything about how I work. I make digest-sized books, short enough to read in one sitting, written in plain language with no padding, and priced at a fair and friendly number. It's no accident that my prices nearly always land on a single digit with a nine at the end. The West Marches Guidebook is still about five dollars, and it has passed nearly four thousand copies.

There is a platform reason for pricing that low, too, and it has to do with how a storefront decides which books get shown to strangers. The short version is that a cheap book which sells widely buys you credibility an expensive book can't. The long version is a chapter of its own.

One honest aside. I have a steady day job, so this isn't how I put food on the table. But everything here was built in evenings and stolen weekends, and it still moved real numbers.

Here is one more thing the twenty years bought me, and it is the one I would most like you to skip.

In all three of those talks I mentioned at the start, I called advertising the best money I had ever spent. But it turned out to not be the case, after all.

I measured everything the books earned and divided it by what I paid for ads, which produces a lovely number and tells you nothing at all. Nearly half of one year's earnings went back out that way, and when I finally sat down with the whole picture, I struggled to find those sales anywhere.

That does not make advertising worthless. The campaigns that did pay for themselves ran alongside something new, a book or a bundle or a price that was only good that week. The ones that emptied the account ran for months with nothing new behind them.

What I can see in my own numbers is that ads amplify what is already working rather than creating new opportunities. Timing and intention decide which one you get, and no budget fixes the difference.

Underneath it all sits the thing that changed how I think. A reader who comes back is worth several times a reader who buys once, and my most loyal readers are worth several times that again. The real business is the second sale. Which means the most valuable thing you can do the week after a launch is not to advertise it. It's to start the next one.

The strongest buying pattern in my whole catalog is book one of a series leading straight to book two. So build for that on purpose. Write book one so it ends where book two begins, put the link in the back matter, and let every copy already sold do the advertising for the next.

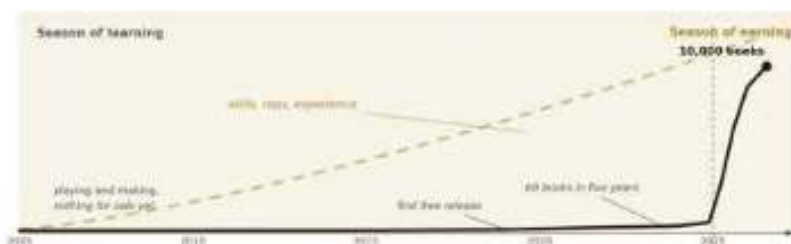
Bundles do the same job inside a single order. Each book costs less, and the reader still spends more than they would have on one title. A fair discount for them, a bigger basket for me.

It is also why I keep old titles alive instead of retiring them. A three-year-old book still sells, because every new release points back at it.

The honest timeline

A season of learning, then a season of earning.

Now comes the part the fancy Instagram posts never show, because it is boring. Building something takes time and effort. More of both than you really want.



Think of it as two seasons. First comes the season of learning. That is Make, Give, and Grow, and it is long. Worse, you have no control over when it ends. Mine ran for twenty years. I fell into tabletop roleplaying back in 2005, and for two decades I played, made things, gave things away, and slowly got better, with almost nothing that looked like success from the outside. From 2019 into 2024 I sold sixty-nine books on DriveThruRPG. That's not a typo. Sixty-nine books in five years, for about ninety dollars. Years of work with a small, kind tip at the end.

But here's what all that work was actually building, though I couldn't see it at the time. Every release taught me something about layout, writing, design, pricing, or what a product page has to say before someone clicks.

Every free download added a name to a list. Every finished book made the next one faster to make. None of that shows up in a sales report, which is exactly why the flat years feel like failure when they are really an apprenticeship.

Then, if you keep going, the season of earning arrives. For me it arrived in 2025. When my best seller launched that May, those sixty-nine books were still the whole of it. The launch moved two hundred and fifty in its first week. One week had beaten six years four times over, from the same guy, using the same skills.

The difference was everything I had picked up along the way, and the crowd, almost seven thousand free downloads and three and a half thousand readers gathered during the flat years, and the new book landed in front of all of them at once.

By the end of 2025, nearly six thousand books had sold in a single year, and once the line tips upwards, it climbs quicker than you were ready for.

Read that again. One week. Six years.

From the outside that looks like an overnight success. Behind the curtain there is a long, patient, almost embarrassingly flat line, followed by a steep rise at the end.

I think a lot of people quit somewhere along the flat part, and the cruel thing is that they have no idea how close they are to their own rise. Some of them never knew a second season existed at all. So if you are somewhere on the flat part, keep going. One step, one publication, at a time.

And the flat part isn't actually flat. Underneath it the list is growing, the craft is sharpening, the digital shelf is filling. None of that guarantees a second season. It only means you are still there when the right thing lands in front of the right crowd. All of it is invisible in the numbers until the day it isn't.

So expect the learning season, and build for it. It asks for long hours with no applause, it gets lonely, and it takes some stubbornness to keep moving toward something you cannot see yet. It also means judging yourself by things you control while the sales are slow. Did you release something this month? Did the list grow? Did you learn one thing you did not know before? Those are season one scores, and they're the only ones worth keeping during season one.

And hear this part clearly. Yes, it takes a while. No, it's not too late to begin. The best day to start was years ago. The second best is today. A cliché, I know. Also completely true.

I am probably only a few years ahead of you, not a decade. You can follow the rest of it as it happens by joining the newsletter at kripublishing.com

Your first step this week

Small enough to start today.

You don't need a five-year plan. You need one first step you can take this week, ideally this very afternoon. Here it is.

1. Pick the smallest real thing you could finish in a week. One page is enough.
2. Write the one sentence: who it is for, and what it does for them.
3. Make a rough, ugly version. Finished and ugly beats perfect and imaginary, every single time.
4. Put it out free, somewhere your people already gather, and ask two or three of them what they think.

That's Make and Give, both started in a single afternoon, and Grow begins the moment you do it twice. The checklist at the back takes it from there.

Print it, and tick your way down as you go.

If you're already telling yourself you don't have the time, let me push back, gently. I didn't have it either. I built most of what I sell in stolen scraps of time, like on the bus, in the half hour after the house fell asleep, on a plane with the wifi off and nothing else to do. You almost certainly have more of those little windows of opportunity than you think. I'm fairly sure the phone in your pocket has eaten a few of them already.

Take the afternoon, and you're already past the hardest part of all of it, which was never the work. It was starting.

What comes next

Hopefully this is enough to get you moving.

A fuller book is coming. I won't promise you a date, because I'd rather surprise you than let you down. This book is the map. The DTRPG Bestseller Blueprint is the manual, and it covers what would not fit in a short book: what a returning reader is actually worth, the price behind ten thousand sales, and why the storefront shows some books and buries others. I am looking forward to handing over the rest of it, so you get to start with everything I did not have.

If this guide helped, leave your address and I'll send a note the moment it lands, plus the odd short, useful thing in between. No noise, and easy to leave whenever you like.

Sign up at: kr1publishing.com

If you would rather talk than read, there is also a Discord. A small room of people making things and showing work before it is finished. I am there most days, and you are welcome.

Come say hello: <https://discord.gg/3xvckbcKz8>

It started as a hobby, and most of what I know I learned by getting it wrong first. These days I publish other people too, all of them people I knew before we signed anything. That is what happens when you stick around long enough.

Thank you for reading this far. Now go make your small thing. I mean it.

All the best, Karl

The Checklist

The whole path on one page. Print it, tick it off.

MAKE

- ☐ Pick one small thing you can finish in a week
- ☐ Aim it at one real problem, for one real person
- ☐ Finish it, even if it is ugly

GIVE

- ☐ Release it free on DriveThruRPG, or pay what you want
- ☐ Switch on follower and mailing lists before you launch
- ☐ Read every comment and note what repeats

GROW

- ☐ Run the loop again, and again
- ☐ Watch for the shift: downloads in hours, names you recognize
- ☐ Wait to sell until people are waiting for you

SELL

- ☐ Cut friction before you add pages
- ☐ Price it so the value is obviously bigger
- ☐ Keep it single digits, with a nine at the end
- ☐ Point each release at the one before it

Start this week. Tick the first box.

I believe in you, seriously.

Also from KR1 Publishing

[West Marches Campaign Playstyle Guidebook](#)

How to run a big, open, player-driven campaign without three free weekends of prep. Also available as an audiobook, narrated by the author.



[West Marches Playkit](#)

The Guidebook together with the Game Master Workbook, Party Ledger and Player Journal. Everything a table needs to run and record a campaign, in PDF or print.



[The Hexcrawl series](#)

System-agnostic guides for wilderness exploration play: Campaign Style, Encounter Design and Worldbuilding Design. Written by Matthijs Holter.



[Roll for Innovation](#)

A short essay on AI and creativity in tabletop roleplaying, written for designers who feel conflicted about it. It argues neither side. Also as an audiobook.



[Gründer: Business Adventure Game](#)

An OSR-inspired game about founding a company and chasing funding, built for one-shot play. Created by Petter Fornes.



Everything above is on DriveThruRPG. Search for KR1 Publishing, or check out the [Complete Digital Bundle](#), which collects every English title in the catalog at a bundle price.

